Source: Pollniti, Analysis by Nalin Mehta, Rishabh Srivastava, https://pollniti.com/live.html#, 24 May 2019

NaMo App vs the Congress's Shakti Platform

The gulf between the trajectories of the NaMo app and the Congress's Shakti platform is reflective of this. By March 2019, the NaMo app had been downloaded 10 million times across Android and iOS platforms, and sold merchandise worth over ₹5 crore. The app, which came pre-configured on Jio phones, has a closed Twitter-like ecosystem, allowing users to post their own content, and also serves as an important two-way system for information-gathering and for surveys.[61]

The NaMo app gave the BJP distinct advantages. Modi conducted a large number of live interactions with party workers using the app. 'The prime minister did a great deal of his direct outreach to booth-level party workers through the app,' says Malviya. 'We used technology to connect with our grassroots workers and we did five constituencies at a time, with the PM speaking to booth-level karyakartas down to the bottom of the pyramid, which was quite impactful. This was pure digital play. It was a lot about who he is as an individual, what he does and so on. For a party, which was a cadre-based party, to have the prime minister of that party speak to the booth-level broker is a different high all together.'

The BJP conducted over two dozen such interactions on the NaMo app between September and January 2019. 'We used to do five Lok Sabha constituencies at a time,' says Malviya. 'This would happen say once or twice a week, depending on how we could organise it.' I asked him how the BJP's digital-media team works operationally, and he says, 'The prime minister's app is managed by the BJP. We have a full dedicated team that does, we do everything that is required to leverage that app. The BJP social media is a content team which is basically like a small newsroom. We cover all rallies of our prime minister and now that of the working president's. Small snippets of their speeches are put out immediately after they have finished. So that if people can't watch all 50 minutes of a speech say, they at least consume fifteen minutes of it in small capsules on social [media] and YouTube. These capsules are two-